

CodeAlpha Cyber Security Internship

TASK 2 — PHISHING AWARENESS TRAINING

A practical awareness module on phishing attacks, fake websites, social engineering, and safe online practices.

Project Objective

This project creates a phishing-awareness training module that helps users recognize phishing emails and fake websites, understand social-engineering tactics, and follow practical steps to avoid becoming victims.

Task requirements covered

- Recognizing phishing emails and fake websites
- Understanding social-engineering tactics
- Best practices to avoid phishing
- Real-world-style examples for awareness
- Interactive quiz for learner engagement

1. What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a social-engineering attack in which an attacker attempts to trick a person into revealing sensitive information, opening a malicious link or attachment, or taking an unsafe action. Attackers commonly imitate trusted organizations or people.

2. Common Types of Phishing

- Email phishing — deceptive messages sent through email.
- Spear phishing — highly targeted messages designed for a specific person or organization.
- Smishing — phishing through SMS or messaging services.
- Vishing — phishing through voice calls.
- Fake websites — websites designed to imitate legitimate login, payment, or service pages.

3. How to Recognize a Phishing Email

Check the sender address carefully. Be cautious of unexpected messages, urgent or threatening language, requests for passwords/OTP/payment, suspicious links, unexpected attachments, unusual grammar, and requests to bypass normal procedures. Do not trust a message only because it contains a familiar logo.

4. How to Check a Link Safely

Before opening a link, inspect the displayed destination. Look for misspelled or unusual domains, unexpected subdomains, shortened links, or domains that do not match the organization. When in doubt, open the organization's website by typing its known address yourself instead of using the message link.

5. Fake Website Warning Signs

A fake site may imitate the design of a trusted service while using a different domain. Warning signs include a strange URL, unexpected login/payment request, poor or inconsistent wording, suspicious pop-ups, and pressure to act immediately. HTTPS alone does not prove that a website is legitimate.

6. Social Engineering Tactics

Attackers exploit human behavior rather than relying only on technical vulnerabilities. Common tactics include urgency, fear, authority, curiosity, rewards, impersonation, and requests for secrecy. The safest response is to pause, verify independently, and use official communication channels.

7. Best Practices

- Never share passwords, PINs, or OTPs because of an unsolicited request.
- Use multi-factor authentication where available.
- Keep operating systems, browsers, and security software updated.
- Avoid opening unexpected attachments or links.
- Verify unusual requests through a trusted channel.
- Report suspicious messages to the appropriate organization or IT/security team.
- Use unique, strong passwords and a password manager where appropriate.

8. Real-World-Style Example 1 — Fake Account Alert

Example message: "Your account will be suspended today. Verify your account immediately using the link below."

Red flags: urgency, threat of suspension, unexpected verification request, and a link that may lead to a

fake login page.

Safe action: Do not click. Visit the organization through its official app or manually entered website and check the account there.

9. Real-World-Style Example 2 — Fake Delivery Message

Example message: “Your parcel could not be delivered. Pay a small fee using this link to reschedule delivery.”

Red flags: unexpected payment request, urgency, and an unfamiliar link.

Safe action: Verify the delivery using the courier’s official website/app or known customer-service contact.

10. What To Do If You Clicked a Phishing Link

Stop interacting with the page. Do not enter additional information. If you entered a password, change it immediately from the legitimate service and review active sessions. If financial information was submitted, contact the relevant financial institution through its official contact method. Report the incident to your organization/IT team when applicable and preserve the suspicious message for investigation.

11. Interactive Phishing Awareness Quiz

Question	Correct answer
Q1. Which is a strong warning sign?	A) Unexpected urgency and a request for sensitive information
Q2. What should you do with a suspicious login link?	A) Avoid clicking it and visit the service through a trusted route
Q3. What is smishing?	A) Phishing conducted through SMS or messaging
Q4. Is HTTPS alone proof that a website is legitimate?	A) No
Q5. An unknown caller asks for an OTP. What should you do?	A) Do not share it; independently verify the request
Q6. Which tactic uses fear or time pressure?	A) Social engineering through urgency or intimidation
Q7. What is the safest way to verify an unexpected account alert?	A) Use the organization's official app/site or known contact method
Q8. What should you do after entering a password on a suspected fake site?	A) Change the password using the legitimate service and review account activity

12. Mini Activity — Spot the Phish

Read a suspicious message and identify at least three warning signs: sender identity, urgency, request for sensitive information, suspicious link/domain, unexpected attachment, or unusual wording. Then explain the safe action you would take.

13. Conclusion

Phishing attacks succeed when people are pressured into acting before verifying. The most important habit is to pause and independently verify unexpected requests. Awareness, careful link checking, strong authentication, software updates, and prompt reporting can significantly reduce phishing risk.

Prepared for: CodeAlpha Cyber Security Internship — Task 2

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